

# 60 Seconds With... Luke Leigh

Someone at work asked me to fill in a company profile for the Engage portal. I did. Then I thought it probably belonged here too.

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## How This Ended Up Here

A colleague from the internal comms team at [Rail Delivery Group](https://www.raildeliverygroup.com/) got in touch and asked if I'd be up for doing a "60 Seconds With..." profile for the company's [Microsoft Viva Engage](https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-viva/engage) platform — Microsoft's replacement for Yammer, for those of us who remember when that was a thing. It's what RDG uses for internal communications: news, updates, the occasional "well done everyone" post, and — apparently — short profiles of the people behind the job titles. I said yes. And when I said yes, I was just as surprised as they were.

I'll be honest: infrastructure people aren't typically the ones being asked to put their name to anything. We're the ones who fix the thing that was quietly broken before anyone noticed, then disappear again. So being asked to write a profile — something deliberately visible — felt mildly out of character. But the questions were decent ones, and I figured if I'm going to be at RDG for the long haul, I might as well let people know there's an actual person behind the support tickets.

Once it was done, I looked at it and thought — well, this is actually a reasonable summary of who I am and what I'm about. The kind of thing that could sit quite usefully on the blog, where people who've found their way here via GitHub or a PowerShell rabbit hole might actually want to know a bit of context about who wrote all this. So here it is, lightly reformatted and with a bit more room to breathe than an intranet card allows.

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# The Job

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**Tell us about your role at RDG — in terms a 10-year-old could understand.**

*You know that trick where someone whips the tablecloth off without disturbing the plates? That's essentially the job — replacing systems and keeping everything running whilst nobody notices. The goal is that nobody ever has to notice. If they do notice, something's probably gone wrong. It helps that I've been doing it long enough to know what to touch and what to definitely leave alone — and honestly, the second category is the more important one.*

**What do you enjoy most about your job?**

*The problem-solving, without question. There's something deeply satisfying about automating a task that used to eat hours of my day — not just to make things quicker, but so that nobody ever has to do it again. I genuinely can't stand repeating the same task twice..... Life's too short for conveyor-belt work, and there are far too many interesting problems left.*

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# On the Railway

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**If you could change one thing about the rail industry, what would it be?**

*It'd be the assumption that everyone's online and on social media. When something goes wrong, updates tend to head to Twitter first — but I've stood on a platform with blank screens and no announcements, not knowing what's happening. I work in IT and I'm barely on social media myself, so I do think there's still a place for just telling people things at the point where they're standing.*

**Do you have a family or historical connection to the railway?**

*Not that I'm aware of — though I've spent years commuting from Southend to London by train, so if sheer accumulated time on the network counts for anything, I might be in with a chance. Whether that constitutes a connection probably depends on how generous the definition is.*

**Favourite UK train journey?**

*By default, the Southend to London line — I've done it enough times to have opinions about every station en route. Whether that level of familiarity qualifies as a favourite is debatable, but at this point it's basically home.*

## Life Outside the Office

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### What is a fun fact about you?

*My home office is a converted shipping container — bought from eBay, which I maintain is a perfectly normal way to acquire office space. It's been through six separate redesigns since 2011. On reflection, 'fun fact' might be underselling it slightly.*

### What do you like to do in your free time?

*Most of my spare time looks suspiciously like work — writing scripts, tinkering with home automation, and sharing things on GitHub (<https://github.com/BanterBoy>), that I'm fairly convinced someone else will find useful one day. I also play Airsoft with my son, which has its own blog at [digitaltak.lukeleigh.com](https://digitaltak.lukeleigh.com/) (<https://digitaltak.lukeleigh.com/>). — because apparently one blog wasn't enough. The rest is family time, and the occasional DIY project tackled with considerably more enthusiasm than expertise.*

## Worth Saying Out Loud

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### What's the best piece of advice you have received?

*My dad's — simple as that. If you don't know something, look it up. He was talking about a word or something you'd find in an encyclopaedia at the time (which tells you approximately how old I am), but I've applied it to pretty much everything since. Every technology I've taught myself, every problem I've worked through — it all started with the same instinct. I think it explains a lot about how I've ended up where I am.*

### What are you most proud of professionally or personally?

*Professionally, it's probably the automation frameworks I've built that are still running reliably long after I've moved on to other things — which I'd like to think says something about the quality of the design rather than anything particularly clever I did. Personally, I'm proud of the balance I've managed to maintain between a demanding career and family life.*

# ? The Fun Bit

## Favourite book, TV, or film recommendation?

*The Princess Bride – both the book and the film, which I end up watching at least once a year. My favourite line is Inigo Montoya's "You keep using that word. I do not think it means what you think it means." I'll be honest, it's also the line I think of most often in IT meetings.....Timeless, for entirely different reasons depending on which side of the table you're sitting on.*

## What would be your specialist subject on Mastermind?

*PowerShell, probably – though working in infrastructure means covering such a broad range of skills that I'm not sure I ever actually got around to specialising in anything. I've been using it daily since before half the people I work with had heard of it.....which is either impressive or a sign I should get out more. Possibly both.*

## What's your go-to karaoke tune?

*Not blessed with the voice or the moves for it, I'm afraid. If there's ever a microphone going spare I'm far more likely to tell a joke than attempt a song.*

## If you could live anywhere in the world, where would it be?

*Somewhere that probably requires a time machine as much as a plane ticket – Hong Kong in the 1980s, when I was about seven. I'm not sure how much of it I actually remember versus how much I've romanticised, but I do know we spent most of the time at the swimming pool, which sounds about right.*

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